

Jens Jensen, Native Plants, and the Concept of Nordic Superiority

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Abstract: *The writings of German landscape architecture historians Joachim Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gert Gröning have brought into question the ethical underpinnings of natural landscaping. Citing the work of Willy Lange, a German "garden architect" whose work foreshadowed and became the foundation for designs by Alwin Seifert and other National Socialist landscape engineers and planners, they develop a critique which suggests that the preservation of native landscapes and the exclusive use of native plants in gardens is both "racist" and "anti-human." Wolschke-Bulmahn has also criticized Jens Jensen, the Midwest American landscape architect who is well known for his advocacy and use of native plants during the first four decades of the twentieth century. This critique is made by highlighting excerpts of Jensen's writings in German landscape journals of the 1930s, which Wolschke-Bulmahn believes show Jensen's support for the racial policies of the National Socialist Party.*

This paper attempts to answer this critique against Jensen and against the contemporary use of native plants. We review Jensen's life from his birth in Dybbøl, Denmark to his death in Ellison Bay, Wisconsin, looking at the personal and social influences that made him an advocate of democracy and the use of native plants. We describe Jensen as a man, like many of his generation, with racist tendencies, but one who was not sympathetic to the National Socialist (or American, or British) program of euthanasia. Instead, we view him as a person struggling with the way "progress" had outstripped the ritual and spiritual aspects of life in the "modern" world. Jensen realized that natural places and the use of native plants represented, not a superiority over others, but a way to help everyone, especially immigrants, establish a relationship with their new home. Furthermore, we argue that today's use of native plants and the emphasis on "place" are part of this thought: an attempt to diversify and humanize, in a positive way, a post-modern world that has become increasingly homogenized and artificial.

June 27, 1940

Dear Jens,

I hear that they are calling you Hitler up in Door County. I don't know whether it is because you are acting the dictator and leaving the impression that you would like to determine the policies of Door County according to totalitarian methods or whether it is because you, like myself, are so thoroughly imbued with the possibilities of the new social structure which we are entering, and which will be founded upon the soil, that your enthusiasm gives people this impression. After all, there are values in that

which has gone before that we must conserve as well as values in the new and adventurous toward which we must reach. If we try to lead our fellow comrades too rapidly along new paths, we may do more injury to the better life ahead than if we move slowly.
Yours,
Franz Aust!

From his arrival in Chicago in 1886 until his death in Door County, Wisconsin in 1951, the flamboyant and outspoken Danish

immigrant Jens Jensen worked diligently to connect people to the natural landscape of the Upper Midwest. Today, his legacy is synonymous with the artistic use of native plants, council rings, the Prairie School, the conservation of rural and urban "wild" areas, and The Clearing—his home and school in Door County (Figure 1). Much has been written about Jensen and his work as a landscape architect. These publications include books by Leonard Eaton (1964), William Tishler (1989), and Robert Grese (1992),



Figure 1. This photo of Jens Jensen at The Clearing, taken by his son-in-law Hud Wheeler, was included in Jensen's article, "Das Haus im garten: ein Gartenheim in Wisconsin," published in August 1937 in *Gartenshönheit*, a German landscape design journal from Berlin. Jensen was in his late seventies at the time. Photograph courtesy of The Clearing.

numerous articles (Christianson 1982; Collier 1975, 1977; Eaton 1960; Fulkerson 1941, 1958; Henderson 1985; Sniderman 1991; Talbot-Stanaway 1993; Vernon 1995); personal remembrances (Fulkerson and Corson 1972; Telfer, Sr. 1982); a number of theses (Christy 1976; Grese 1984; Windesheim 1975); and some unpublished papers (Collier 1982; Vernon 1986). In addition, valuable information about Jensen is contained in several books on related topics (Brooks 1972; Condit 1973; Domer 1997; Eaton 1989; and Engel 1983). These authors, while often analytical in their appraisals, have been generally favorable of Jensen's ideas and his work.

Recently, however, two German landscape historians, Joachim Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gert Gröning, "implicated" Jensen in an argu-

ment that ties early twentieth-century German and American advocates of natural gardens to the racial policies of National Socialist Germany (1994a, 1996a, 1996b).

This phase in the development of German landscape architecture demonstrates how racist ideas about humans and their alleged relationship to the natural environment, became articulated more and more aggressively in Germany under changing political conditions and were finally used to justify the expulsion and extermination of human beings. (Wolschke-Bulmahn 1996, p. 12)

One of their main focal points has been how racial attitudes, romanticism, and an understanding of ecology influenced the natural garden designs of various German landscape architects, especially Willy Lange and

Alwin Seifert (1989, 1992, 1996). They have also examined how the National Socialists used a racially-derived theme of "blood and soil" in planning the landscape features of German-occupied Poland (1987, 1992), and in the debate between advocates of architectonic and natural garden styles in Germany (1989). Wolschke-Bulmahn, in a paper titled, *Ethics and Morality, Questions in the History of Garden and Landscape Design: A Preliminary Essay* (1994b), argues against the idea of human society regulated by the laws of nature (ecocentrism), especially in authoritarian political situations (ecofascism). This concern arises because of what he sees as fascist influences in today's German Green Party² and because of German journalists and others who, he claims, use the word *ecological* as if it gives moral authority to their arguments. Although they offer more research than solutions, and write that they have nothing against the use of native plants, it is obvious that Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröning favor an international, as opposed to regional, approach to garden design.

Since they began publishing articles in the United States, their work has attracted considerable attention. Moreover, their writings have paralleled the 50th anniversary of World War II, the controversy surrounding the 1994 White House directive regarding landscaping of federal grounds,³ and the efforts of conservative political elements in the United States. Perhaps the best known American to enter this discussion about gardening and politics is Michael Pollan, a garden writer and polemicist. Citing the findings of Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröning in his 1994 essay "Against Nativism," Pollan remarked:

It's hard to believe that there is nothing more than scientific concern about invasive species behind the current fashion for natural gardening and native plants in America—not when our national politics are rife with anxieties about immigration and isolationist sentiment. The garden isn't the only corner of American culture where nativism is in flower now." (*New York Times Magazine*, 1994)

Like Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening, Pollan advocates "a cosmopolitan garden, one that borrows freely from all the world's styles and floras. . . ."⁴

Not surprisingly, such arguments have disturbed people who advocate the use of native plants, as well as devotees of Jensen. They contend that Wolschke-Bulmahn, Gröening and Pollan misrepresent the contemporary use of native plants and natural landscaping by implying that its underlying principles are racially and politically motivated. Moreover, these advocates deny that natural landscaping is a restrictive form of gardening. Instead they consider it a matter of making personal choices and establishing a "sense of place" in an increasingly homogeneous world. They also disagree with those who claim we cannot define a species as native to a given place. On this subject, Wolschke-Bulmahn has written,

There is, however, much disagreement on what constitutes a "native" plant. . . . The idea of using only plants representative of a particular state or country may be an interesting garden motif, but it has nothing at all to do with nature and nativeness. (1997, p. 21)

However, American taxonomists find it relatively easy to define a native species. According to ecologists such as Neil Diboll, "Being native is a function of two factors: location and time" (Marinelli 1995). Using Diboll's criteria, ecologists and native plant advocates define native plants as those species that existed in a particular region of North America prior to European settlement. However, we agree that being a native plant has little, if anything, to do with being a "superior" plant or a plant "best-adapted" for a particular region or situation. We have seen too many situations where non-native plants such as kudzu or purple loosestrife simply out-compete native species. Being native is, however, more appropriate in terms of planting a garden that reflects a pre-European settlement landscape, and using native plants does mean that we are working with species that can provide local diversity.

The controversial writings of Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening have generated a much-needed dis-

cussion about natural landscaping, its relationship to larger social issues and, indirectly, our use of language. However, despite their excellent research into aspects of this phenomenon, several of their positions remain problematic. First, they seriously underestimate or fail to acknowledge the influence of many other ideas relating to the development of the Nordic superiority myth and its evolution in Germany and elsewhere. Second, they fail to differentiate between associational and causal statements, thereby decreasing the credibility of their case, especially regarding the influence of natural landscaping. Third, they present a narrow view of Jens Jensen—a portrait that highlights "racist" attitudes while failing to mention Jensen's complex nature, specifically his mixing of progressive, democratic ideals with the theory of environmental determinism.

Point 1: Although central to their argument, Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening fail to discuss the rise of "discriminatory racism" or the idea of ranking humans by racial type. In fact, this idea has a well-documented history that emerges out of the Enlightenment—an era known for its devotion to reason, science, and the notion that human history represents a continuous line of progress. Since Europeans were also colonizing the globe at this time, they used methods of categorizing the plants, animals, and humans they found that reflected this mode of thinking. Considering themselves the ultimate example of human progress, Europeans described the other humans, whom they divided into racial types, as "exotic" and even "remarkable," but ultimately "inferior."

Historians point out that Hitler and the National Socialists drew their ideas about race from a line of thinking that dates back to the 1850s and the publication of two books: *Essai sur l'inégalité des races humaines* (Essay on the Inequality of Human Races) by the French diplomat Joseph-Arthur, comte de Gobineau, and *Die Naturgeschichte des Volkes als Grundlage einer deutschen Socialpolitik* (Natural History of the German People as a Foundation of German Social Politics) by the German journalist and historian Wilhelm Heinrich

Riehl. These two books set a tone of racial difference that permeated European thought. For his part, Gobineau theorized that race was the primary force behind world history, and equally important, that this conclusion was based on science (Proctor 1988, p. 12). Riehl's tome, meanwhile, illustrated the distinctions between rural and urban Germans—a theme the National Socialists would exploit in their propaganda against Jewish merchants. The National Socialists also drew upon the writings of Houston Stewart Chamberlain who, in 1899, published *The Foundations of the Nineteenth Century* (*Die Grundlagen des neunzehnten Jahrhunderts*). In this book, Chamberlain established the Aryan stereotype (tall, blond, blue-eyed) within a framework of religious mysticism. He also claimed that Western Aryan peoples were responsible for Europe's greatness and that Jewish influence was primarily negative.^{5,6} Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening also make no mention of Friedrich Ratzel, a German geographer and ethnographer, whose essay "Lebensraum" or "Living Space" (1901) provided the "scientific" basis for Hitler's plan to "annex" Poland and convert its landscape into one "appropriate" for Germans.⁷

Strangely, Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening fail to mention these influences, except for briefly noting Chamberlain's influence on Willy Lange (Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening 1989, p. 54). They do "indict" Ernst Haeckel and thus, by implication, the science of ecology to which Haeckel provided the name. However, as historian of science Robert McIntosh explains:

It is clear that ecology did not emerge fully formed from the head of Haeckel any more than biology emerged from Burdach, Treviranus, and Lamarck or genetics from Mendel. Haeckel's coinage of *ecology* in 1866 did not provoke a rash of ecological studies or prompt the identification of biologists as ecologists; in fact, hardly anyone noticed the new term for over two decades. . . . Haeckel provided the name but little substance for the new science. (McIntosh 1985, pp. 22–23)

Another historian of ecology, Donald Worster agrees:

... an entirely new generation of trail-blazers now entered the field—a vanguard of self-consciously professional “ecologists,” as they called themselves. They, not Haeckel . . . , would be mainly responsible for identifying the contours of the modern science of ecology. They would give the mere word concrete substance. . . . (Worster 1977, p. 193)

By identifying Haeckel with ecology, Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening claim that an association exists between his ideas about the ranking of races (racist ideas Haeckel clearly outlines in his 1883 publication, *Pedigree of Man and Other Essays*) with the science of ecology in general. In this way, it appears that they hope to establish ecology as having underlying racist tendencies and thereby debunk its role as justification for “ecocentric” thought.

While Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening focus on some of the influences surrounding National Socialism, they ignore other factors that most historians consider of greater importance. For example, in *Landscape and Memory*, historian Simon Schama convincingly describes the German ideas and myths about nature and culture that held sway throughout their history, including during the period of National Socialism. Nevertheless, he does not feel the need to indict ecology or environmentalism because of what happened to the Jews, Gypsies, and others under the National Socialist regime:

It is, of course, painful to acknowledge how ecologically conscientious the most barbaric regime in modern history actually was. Exterminating millions of lives was not at all incompatible with passionate protection for millions of trees. This is not to make an obscene syllogism: to imply in any way that modern environmentalism has any kind of historical kinship with totalitarianism. (Schama 1995, p. 119)

Historian Stanley Payne, taking another perspective, observes:

The keys to understanding the German catastrophe do not lie in grasping any innate or inevitable tendencies in German life or in defining deterministic political and cultural influences, but in understanding the interplay of destruc-

tive ultra nationalist tendencies with the unique chain of crisis and traumas which afflicted German society in the two decades between 1914 and 1933. This “concatenation of crisis” involved a sequence of traumas unparalleled in the history of other European countries during that generation. The onset of a massive war in 1914 was followed by great human losses and suffering, a sort of wartime dictatorship, and some remarkable military victories followed by a sudden and inexplicable collapse, albeit in the face of great odds. After military defeat came a harsh and humiliating peace, accompanied by convulsive political change following the collapse of the imperial government, together with the threat (and partial reality) of social revolution accompanied by an unprecedented brutalization of public life and mass violence. This occurred within a framework of great loss of national wealth, unemployment, and decline in living standards. Temporary political stabilization was followed within a year by new efforts at violent political rebellion from the right and left, and three years later by a partial military invasion that led to unimaginable hyperinflation, temporary economic collapse, and the destruction of savings, with further attempted armed revolts from [the] right and left. Even the five years of democratic stabilization (1924–1929) were a period of considerable social and economic uncertainty, as sizable unemployment persisted, the country became almost totally dependent on foreign credit, and middle-class interests continued to be threatened economically and fragmented politically. This shaky recovery was soon followed by the Great Depression, leading to truly massive unemployment, total political fragmentation, and major political and social crisis. By mid-1930 the democratic system had already stalemated, and the government was directed by non-parliamentary administrations which ruled by decree but lacked majority support and were completely unsuccessful in ending the political or economic crisis. Though National Socialism was not merely the product of this succession of unprecedented traumas, it would have been impossible without them. (*A History of Fascism, 1914–1945*, pp. 148–149)

Thus, while Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening have made an important contribution to the history of landscape architecture, it seems clear that this history needs to be placed within the context of the larger social, economic, and political framework of the periods involved.

Point 2. In their articles, Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening use a technique—colligative explanation—that is common practice in preparing historical accounts. Utilizing this method, the historian weaves together many aspects of an idea or series of events, thereby providing “evidence” for their historical interpretations. However, in using this technique some researchers, including Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening, fail to differentiate between associational (a statement describing concepts that occur or exist together) and causal (a statement describing the causal relationship between two concepts or events) statements made during the course of their exposés. This can be problematic because causal statements often lead us to believe that if we know the cause, we should then be able to predict those situations in which a similar event will happen. Associational (correlative) statements, on the other hand, do not allow us to make predictions.

In their work, Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening fail to distinguish between causes and associations, allowing the reader to reach ambiguous conclusions. Some might, as the writing of Michael Pollan demonstrates, see a neo-Nazi in virtually every prairie, meadow, or woodland garden—a logical fallacy known as the “fallacy of the undistributed middle,” where one imputes all the characteristics of a given class to any object having one of these characteristics (Peters 1991, pp. 241–242). Meanwhile, gardeners and restorationists may dismiss the whole discussion of these authors as frivolous, academic drivel or become embittered for what they perceive as an attack on their attempt to relate to nature.

We believe that both ecology and evolution theory, as they were understood at the time, were used in the United States and Europe to legitimize a wide variety of related

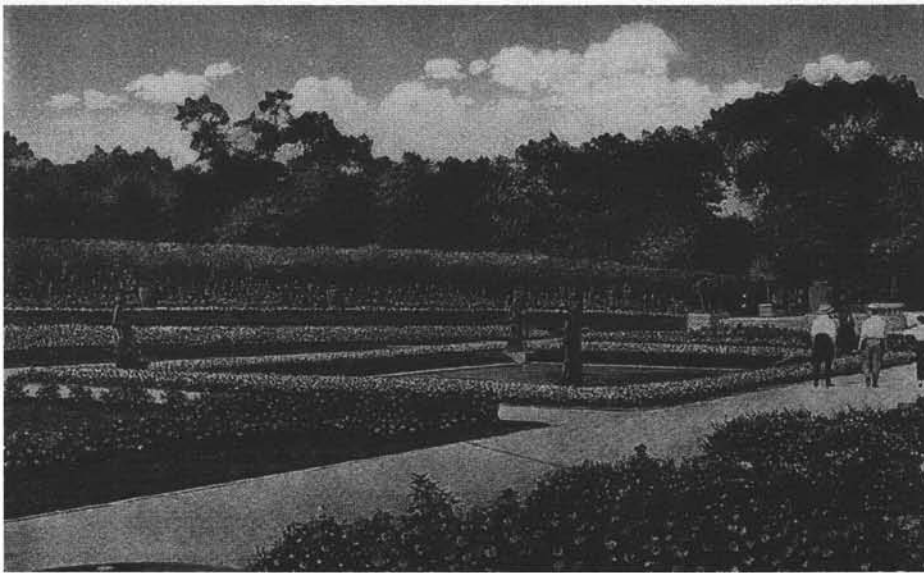


Figure 2. Sunken garden at Humboldt Park, one of Chicago's West Parks designed by Jensen who became its superintendent in 1905. When reminded of these early formal gardens in his later years, Jensen referred to them as "follies of my youth."

and unrelated ideas. Moreover, we maintain that: 1) the use of these particular ideas was part of the larger trend in modern, urbanized society to legitimate all actions in a rational, scientific manner; 2) such legitimizations were dependent on a given country's existing political and economic situations; 3) when historians describe links between ideas of the past and the political policies they helped legitimize, they must do so carefully, so as to avoid overemphasizing the influence that any one idea may have had on the overall outcome of a particular policy or political activity; and 4) one should be wary of drawing conclusions between past activities or ideas and today's similar, but different, activities and ideas.

But what about Jens Jensen, his ideas about the use of native plants, and its relationship to racial superiority? To address this, we will present Wolschke-Bulmahn's "portrait" of Jensen and then provide our overview of Jensen's life and his place within the midwestern cultural scene. Although this is not a definitive analysis of Jensen, we hope to provide a studied glimpse of a fascinating and, necessarily, complex individual (Figure 2).

Wolschke-Bulmahn's Jensen

Prior to becoming Director of Landscape Studies at Dumbarton Oaks in 1992, Wolschke-Bulmahn had not written about Jens Jensen. However, in a presentation made in 1993, he described Jensen as a garden designer with a "racist attitude" (1994a, p. 26), citing the following sentence from Jensen's book, *Siftings*: "I have stated before that man is more or less influenced by traditions, but I have also stated that it is the spirit of these traditions which is of value, which is part of the race. . . ." (1990, p. 5). Wolschke-Bulmahn finds that it is

remarkable that Jensen, as did Lange earlier on, stressed the alleged existence of differences between Scandinavian races and Latin races; he [Jensen] stated: "The influence of the Mediterranean, where the Latin races live, has created a distinct character quite different from that of the Germanic races." (*Siftings*, 1990, p. 25) (Wolschke-Bulmahn 1994a, p. 26)

Wolschke-Bulmahn also describes Jensen as "even more militant in his ideas about natural garden

design than was his Nazi colleague, Alwin Seifert" (1994a, p. 26). Wolschke-Bulmahn writes: "He [Jensen] wrote to Camillo Schneider [editor of the German journal, *Gartenschönheit*, to which Jensen had been contributing since the mid-1920s] in [April] 1939:"

Seifert seems to distinguish between the garden inside an enclosure and the landscape—here he submits to compromise . . . I cannot see how you can compromise on a difference between the garden and its surrounding; then the garden remains a stranger in its own land. To be true to yourself, I mean true to your native landscape is a very fundamental issue—it is to be, or not to be. In the garden you give assent to one idea and outside its boundary to another. Strange things, grotesque things, usually attractive to the naive, will creep in and the purity of thoughts in garden making suffers. Freaks are freaks and often bastards—who wants a bastard in the garden, the out-of-doors shrine of our home? (p.26)

Wolschke-Bulmahn goes on to say,

To fully understand the significance of Jensen's letter to Schneider and his enthusiasm about the work of Alwin Seifert expressed in this letter, one has to consider that Seifert was one of the two most important Nazi landscape architects. When Jensen commented on his German colleague in this way in 1939, at the height of National Socialism, it is certain that he knew about the role Seifert played in Nazi Germany. This highly political motive of Jensen's rejection of foreign plants and of his plea for natural garden design has been ignored until now. (p. 26)

In a subsequent paper (1996a, pp. 17–18), Wolschke-Bulmahn provides another example of "how Jensen's racism was an important motif in his plea for native plants and what he considered to be "natural" design. He [Jensen] wrote:

The gardens that I created myself shall, like any landscape design, it does not matter where, be in harmony with their landscape environment and the racial characteristics of its inhabitants. They shall express the spirit of America and therefore

be free of foreign character as far as possible. . . . The Latin and the Oriental crept and creeps more and more over the land, coming from the South, which is settled by Latin people, and also from other centers of mixed masses of immigrants. The Germanic character of our race, of our cities and settlements was overgrown by foreign [character]. Latin spirit has spoiled a lot and still spoils things every day; and only sometimes might it be good and enrich our world of forms. (*Die Lichtung/The Clearing*, 1937 *Gartenkunst*)

Viewed in this manner, Jens Jensen appears as an uncompromising, racially-motivated man who may have been a National Socialist, had he not left Schleswig for the United States in 1884. Was Jensen actually a Nazi sympathizer? Could he have been a member of the German-American Bund? Was he a racist? It might be easy to conclude from the previous quotes that he could have been all of these and more. However, a more complete examination of Jensen's life is necessary before we can begin to answer such questions.

Jens Jensen: Another Perspective

Our view of Jens Jensen has its basis in the cultural forces that framed his time, both prior to and following World War I. These forces shaped the social, political, and intellectual framework within which Jensen worked both as a landscape architect and social/environmental activist. Without acknowledging them, we leave ourselves open to a view of the past that is blinded by our present concerns—one that lacks the necessary reinvolverment with past generations to elucidate an authentic history of the period in question.⁹

In order to understand Jens Jensen, one needs to look at his life both in Denmark and the United States. Jensen was born in 1860 near Dybbøl, in the Duchy of Schleswig, Kingdom of Denmark (Figure 3). As Grese points out (1992, pp. 3–4), Jensen's love and respect for the "out-of-doors" developed during his youth in Denmark—from the rural landscape where he grew up, on trips with his father, at many outdoor festivals and celebrations, and from his (high-



Figure 3. Map of Dybbøl area on the Jutland Peninsula of Denmark. The town of Sønderborg is on the right and the gray dot indicates the location of the Jensen family farm. Note the preponderance of earthworks remaining from the Danish/Prussian War which ended in 1864, when Jensen was four years old.

school level) education in a Danish folk school. The folk schools, with their curriculum that included folk songs, ballads, and Norse sagas, gave Jensen a strong sense of attachment to his locale, its people and their traditional language and culture. He would later recreate these childhood lessons at gatherings of the Prairie Club, the Friends of Our Native Landscape, and in the council rings and players' greens of his park designs (Figure 4) (Grese 1992, pp. 122–124, 176–179) in order to unleash the power of ritual experiences.

Another equally important childhood experience for Jensen, and one directly related to an increased emphasis on Danish culture in their folk schools, was the Prussian invasion and occupation of the southern Jutland region of Denmark beginning in 1864. Jensen's childhood home was destroyed because it was in the midst of the battleground of this war. (It was reconstructed, and a short distance away a large new museum was built to commemorate this event.) As a young child, Jensen was deeply influenced by this military activity and, as Eaton describes (1964, p. 5), the memory of his family's buildings

set ablaze by Prussian troops stayed with him throughout his life. However, this memory was not one of bitterness and revenge, but one that shaped his view of war as wasteful and inhuman. This childhood experience may have set the stage for Jensen's later embrace of pacifism. The occupation of his homeland by Prussian troops also impressed upon Jensen the need to maintain one's identity, both as an individual, and as a culture.

Following the war, Schleswig became part, first of the Kingdom of Prussia, then, in 1871, of the German Empire. Following his folk school education, Jensen attended the Tune Agricultural School outside Copenhagen for a brief period, and then was conscripted into the German army. After serving his military duty in Berlin, he returned to Schleswig, and then, with his fiancée, Anne Marie Hansen, left for the United States in 1884. Two years later, they moved to Chicago—"Nature's Metropolis" (Cronon 1991). There Jensen would mature as an artist and a social activist during a period when the United States was undergoing fundamental changes that were transform-

ing it into a more urban, industrial, and multi-cultural society. This was a time of rapid technological and social change that challenged previous assumptions and values. Progress, efficiency, mechanization, and science became the belief system of the period.

Five inter-related phenomena influenced American life during this era:

- the sense of loss engendered by the demise of the "frontier," and the country's rapid social evolution from an agricultural economy into a modern industrial, urban environment, as explained by historian Frederick Jackson Turner;¹⁰
- an international response to the Darwinian paradigm of evolution, both scientifically and spiritually;
- the immigration of southern and eastern Europeans to the United States, beginning in the 1880s, and the subsequent development of "the melting pot" concept to help assimilate them;
- an increasing trend toward nationalism and a centralized government, and the regionalist reaction;
- the belief that an efficient, more perfect society was possible, and the rise of Progressivism¹¹ as a political and social force to establish and maintain that ideology.

Not surprisingly, this dramatic reorganization resulted in a widespread reaction. Established Americans began to reconsider or reinforce their positions within American society, often sensing that their world was in a state of decline. Their reaction was sometimes nostalgic (romantic environmentalism, regionalism), other times reactionary (racism, anti-immigration quotas, elitism), economic (unionization), and caring (settlement houses, progressive labor laws). Often it became a composite of one or more of these responses.

These forces forged the cultural landscape of Jensen's early career and, in no small measure, remained with him his entire life. The closing of the western frontier, for example, influenced Jensen's idealization of America and the Midwest. It was *the* social evolutionary tale—the drama of human habitation of the land beginning with the Native Americans,

then the pioneers, the farmers, and finally the urban dwellers—that was retold in the masques held at Friends of Our Native Landscape, Prairie Club, and other gatherings. This story provided the framework for members of these groups to seek out, experience, and protect "wild" places. They believed that "wild, natural places" such as the Indiana Dunes, state parks, and nature preserves were needed as sanctuaries where urban dwellers could restore their vitality and spirit. In addition, Jensen and others found support in Turner's argument that it was the frontier—the rural countryside—that produced the leaders of the country and provided its source of energy and democratic spirit.¹² Ultimately, Jensen's continued belief in this idea led him away from civilized, urbane Chicago to the rural environs of Door County, Wisconsin. There, at The Clearing, he sought to expand his experience of the "primitive," and to remove himself from modern life.

The ideas swirling around Darwin's theory of evolution served as the foundation and framework for many activities, including science. Jensen was a close friend of the eminent ecologist and educator, Henry Chandler Cowles of the University of Chicago. In addition to spending numerous weekends together visiting woods, prairies, and dunes around Chicago, where they catalogued plants and developed ideas for their respective careers (Grese 1992, p. 52), they also participated in the Prairie Club, the Friends of Our Native Landscape, and in the activities of the Geographic Society of Chicago and the Illinois Academy of Science. Cowles's ecological studies of vegetative succession at the Indiana Dunes were seminal in establishing the study of ecology in the United States (Cowles 1899). However, unlike the most celebrated American ecologist of the time, Frederic Clements, Cowles did not believe that successional forces tended toward a rigid, climax-oriented super organism. Instead, he focused on the individual plant, and described succession as "not a straight-line process. Its stages may be slow or rapid, direct or tortuous and often they are retrogressive. It is a variable approaching a variable

rather than a constant" (McIntosh 1985, pp. 43, 83). This individual, non-rigid approach is also found in Jensen's work where he uses individual plants such as the hawthorn and American plum to make artistic statements. It also is reflected in Jensen's general belief that the successional forces of nature were all that were necessary to maintain his designs, or even that natural changes were welcome as part of the overall process of landscaping (Jensen 1939a, p. 1012; Grese 1992, p. 195).

Evolution also played a part in the development of what was then the leading paradigm in geography—environmental determinism. Geographers and others who espoused this idea maintained that the physical environment determines the cultural make-up of human societies residing within a physiographic region. In 1928, Pitirim A. Sorokin summarized this position as such:

Almost from the beginnings of man's history it has been known that the characteristics, behavior, social organization, social processes and historical destiny of a society depend upon the geographical environment. (Sorokin, 1928, p. 99)

This notion was held by American geographers William Morris Davis, Ellsworth Huntington, Albert Perry Brigham, Griffith Taylor, and, most importantly for this discussion, Ellen Churchill Semple. Semple, who studied in Germany under Friedrich Ratzel, was a lecturer at the University of Chicago and the author of *The Influences of Geographic Environment* (1911). It is very likely that Jensen knew her or heard about her ideas from his acquaintances at the university. In this scientific theory, Jensen probably found support for his belief as a designer that the physical environment causes important cultural and spiritual differences to develop in each race or people.

Jensen's artistic career also developed within the intellectual and social milieu of turn-of-the-century Chicago. Jensen was a member of several social clubs and became acquainted with various writers, poets, and other artists of the period such as Hamlin Garland, Sherwood Anderson, and Carl Sandburg, among

others. He also worked closely with several members of the Prairie School of Architecture, which had its center in Chicago, from where it spread to other areas of the Upper Midwest. Its buildings, with their horizontal lines, dramatized the democratic spirit of the Midwest and its prairies. Jensen had an office in Steinway Hall with many Prairie School architects including Frank Lloyd Wright, Dwight Perkins, Hugh Garden, and Robert Spencer, and was involved with landscape designs for some of their projects. More importantly, he was swept up by the notion that a region's identity could be, and should be, expressed through art.

Evidence of Jensen's working with other artists and Progressive leaders can be found in one of his letters to William Evjue, editor and founder of the progressive newspaper, *The Madison Capitol Times*. It refers to a story regarding a Carl Sandburg poetry reading in Madison during the late 1940s:

Carl [Sandburg] often came to our drafting room in Chicago on Van Buren Street and later at my studio in Ravinia. Frequently did we meet at St. Hubbard's Tavern, back of the Union League Club. In our group was Jane Addams, Louis Sullivan, Sherwood Anderson, Dr. Thancar, Bruce Lloyd, Axel Josephson, Dr. Lowett, and Sandburg. It was a hot bunch that might have blown the tavern up at any minute. . . . And you mention Zona Gale and Edna Ferber—both old friends of mine. Those were the days we tried to reform this confused and naughty United States? There was still red blood in our veins! Thanks for the many dear memories you brought back. (Jensen 1947)

For several decades, Jensen and this group of Chicago intellectuals actually served as a bulwark against nativism. Jane Addams and her colleagues at Hull House saw social action as a means of acclimating newly-arrived immigrants to America. They espoused a belief, rightly or wrongly, that the social and natural environment can influence the way people perceive themselves. They worked hard to create a "community of Americans" by drawing out the best and most characteristic aspects

of each race and people. Hull House also served as a connecting point between the city's intelligentsia and its poor. It championed various causes, including an important campaign for the development of much-needed parks.¹³ In 1906, Jensen explained his vision of park-making and art within this context:

Every nation develops its own art. We are young as a nation and still in the process of crystallization. Every race or nationality brings to us some of its customs and habits which are gradually but surely being molded together, ultimately to form one national character. The environs amongst which the immigrants settle lend their great influence—sung by the poet, painted by the painter and idealized by the gardener. (Jensen 1906, p. 28)

Jensen saw the importance of bringing landscape features of the American Midwest to the immigrants in their parks and playgrounds. This idea first took form in his American Garden in Union Park (1888), a then "novel" planting of native plants that Jensen collected on trips with his family and friends to the outskirts of Chicago. Later, after designing and planting several formal park designs, this concept of idealizing the natural landscape re-emerged in the conservatory at Garfield Park (1907), the "prairie river" in Humboldt Park (1912), and the "prairie river," naturalistic "swimming hole," and creative playground area in Columbus Park (1916) (Figure 4). These efforts, which were all parts of larger pastoral, recreational park plans, represented his attempt to bring the aesthetic power of the primitive/rural to the city and to acclimate immigrants to the Midwest.

There are two reasons why I turned away from the formal design that employed foreign plants. The first reason was an increasing dissatisfaction with the plants and the unyielding design—I suppose dissatisfaction with things as they are is always the fundamental cause of revolt—and the second was that I was becoming more and more appreciative of the beauty and decorative quality of the native flora of this country. (Jensen and Eskil 1930, p. 18)



Figure 4. Children gather at a council ring in Chicago's Columbus Park. By this time in his career Jensen was using this design feature to create a democratic space—an area of community and equality—for storytelling, conversation and meditation. Photograph courtesy of Robert E. Grese.

It is also important to note that Jensen was a man of impeccable integrity who held very strong ideas about democracy, individual responsibility, and honesty. These ideals were tested time and again during his career with the Chicago Parks and, in 1900, they cost him his job because he refused to participate in political corruption. Jensen's principles bore a strong resemblance to those of Louis Sullivan, the architect/poet/philosopher, whom Jensen considered a master artist and a close friend—so close, in fact, that Jensen was at Sullivan's deathbed and his funeral. Both wrote forcefully about the merits of maintaining an authentic democracy of forthright individuals.¹⁴ Again, reflecting Turner's frontier thesis, their thinking held that immigrants on the edge of westward settlement would cast off the shackles of European aristocracy in favor of healthy, self-sufficient individualism and democracy.

After an intense period of activity and legislated reform during the first two decades of the century, the Progressive Era became paralyzed by the onset of World War I. As the United States entered the war against Germany, a zealous process of Americanization began as the federal government demanded and encouraged loyalty from all citizens. Many German immigrants and some Progressives proclaimed their neutrality. Given his abhorrence of war fostered

by his childhood experiences and close association with pacifists such as Jane Addams, Jensen had little support for the war effort.

The conclusion of World War I brought an end to the killing, but the settlement reached at Versailles failed to bring a just and lasting peace. Many intellectuals became alienated from society and there was rioting in American cities, including Chicago.¹⁵ Despite the victory in Europe, a sense of foreboding pervaded the country. Americans feared entanglement in the events unfolding abroad—from the rise of the Bolsheviks in Russia to the Spanish influenza. In a growing wave of isolationism, America attempted to retreat to its own nationalistic shores. Historian John Higham summarizes the sentiments of many Progressives at that time:

... the harsh facts of the post-war world produced, during 1919 and 1920, a general disillusion. The quarreling at Versailles and the class strife that broke out at home and abroad began the process of deflation and embitterment. It went forward under the influence of partisan wrangling in Congress, economic depression, the manifest failure of Americanization, and the scandalous consequences of prohibition. The letdown seriously undermined democratic, cosmopolitan values, for many who held them abandoned a crusading stance, repudiating their ideals as delusive, nationalism as nasty, and society as unsalvageable." (Higham, *Strangers in the Land*, p. 269)

Thus, a pall of xenophobia settled across the United States during the 1920s. Congress passed immigration quotas based on the results of "scientific" IQ tests,¹⁶ while eugenicists continued their work and grew in influence. Meanwhile, the Supreme Court upheld legislation for involuntary sterilization of the "weak and feeble-minded,"¹⁷ and Ku Klux Klan membership grew throughout the country. Sensing the pulse of the nation, Vice-President Calvin Coolidge wrote in *Good Housekeeping*, "America must be kept American. Biological laws show that Nordics deteriorate when mixed with other races."¹⁸ In landscape design, a new slogan—"American Plants for Ameri-

can People"—emerged in popular magazines. However, unlike Jensen, many of those advocating the use of "American plants" did so without regard to a plant's appropriateness to the region.

While Jensen continued to emphasize the use of native plants and the need to preserve natural areas, he was not drawn into this specter of divisiveness, hatred, and fear. In an address to a convention of the Women's International League for Peace and Freedom, which was organized by Jane Addams and held in Chicago, he made his position clear:

I have read *The Passing of the Great Race*, and I see that the author [Madison Grant, see footnote #6] says we [the Nordic race] are going to be eliminated. . . . Now I will say one word about immigration and that is this: That I believe in everybody coming to America. I do not believe in any restriction of the yellow races or black races or any other races. I am willing to take my place in this country with the rest of the world, and if I am to be defeated then I will go down in defeat after I have tried heroically to hold my own. I think it is absolutely wrong to make restrictions against anyone. . . . Either you must be so selfish that you bring yourself only, or you must admit everybody, and I am for everybody. Let everybody come in, the Chinaman as well as the Hindu. (May, 1924)

Contrast this statement with remarks made during the early 1920s by Albert Johnson, chairman of the House Committee on Immigration and Naturalization Services:

The United States of America, a nation great in all things, is ours today. To whom will it belong tomorrow? . . . The United States is our land. If it was not the land of our fathers, at least it may be, and it should be, the land of our children. We intend to maintain it so. The day of unalloyed welcome to all people, the day of indiscriminate acceptance of all races, has definitely ended. (Williamson, Jr. 1996, p. 54)

Jensen's concern was not with immigrants. He believed at that point that they brought a wealth of diverse backgrounds and could be integrated into American society through the transformative power of the natural landscape and the country's democratic ideals. His continuing attention was with maintaining and implementing these ideals through urban planning and design. He argued, as he did in his plan for Chicago's West Park System (Figure 5), that the home was the basis of city life, and that a more socially-responsible, less autocratic approach should be taken to urban planning.

A better architectural and livable city cannot be brought about by grand plans that are instigated from above and thrust upon the people from without; it must come from within and must grow out of the soul of the people themselves. An ideal democracy is not striving for wealth as reflected in the desire for monarchical pomp and splendor, or as expressed in false standards of life; its aims are higher. It stands for human happiness; its slogan is truth. The neighborhood center must be an honest expression of the life of all the people. (*A Greater West Park System* 1920, p. 46)

In the larger picture, anti-modern traditionalists, such as Jensen, were more concerned with losing the authentic, democratic America to forces of centralization, urbanization, and homogenization than to immigrants. Still, Jensen's arguments, and the arguments of Progressive traditionalists like him who favored democratic pluralism, never considered the idea of making American culture anything other than Anglo-Saxon (Williamson, Jr. 1996). It was, after all, their culture and, while Jensen believed everyone should be allowed to immigrate into the country, he would also fight to maintain his cultural identity.

Early in the 1920s, Jensen's career, like that of the Progressive ideology he espoused, began to lose some of its vitality and focus. Frustrated with the city's corrupt political system, he retired from the Chicago Parks Department to concentrate on designing private estates and the conservation work of the Friends of Our Native Landscape. However, in doing

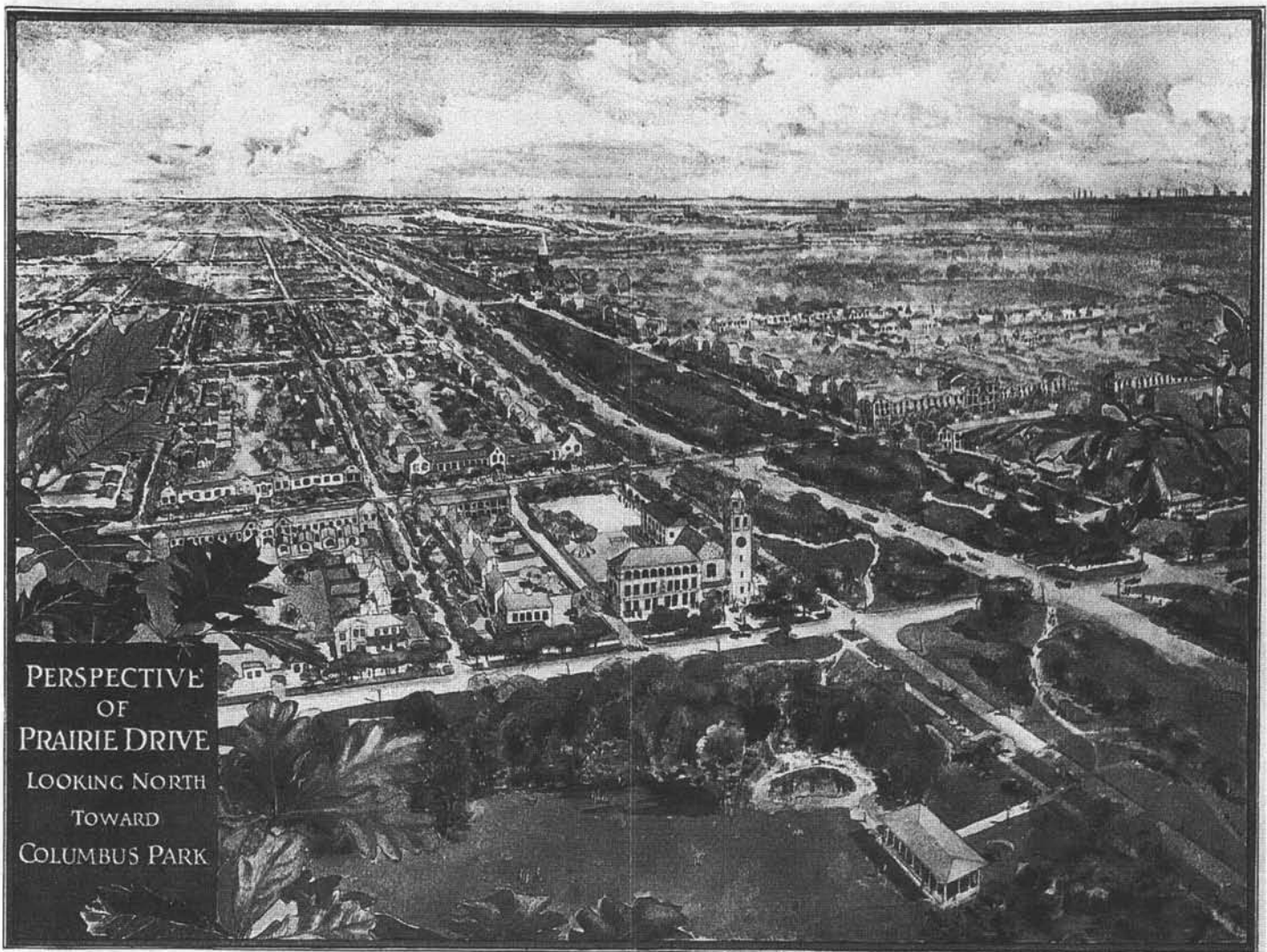


Figure 5. Watercolor rendering from Jensen's visionary 1920 plan for Chicago's Greater West Parks System. The proposed plan, which was not adopted, called for an extensive interconnected system of parks, landscaped streets, and neighborhood amenities such as kitchen and market gardens, neighborhood centers, and residential blocks with communal green space. He concluded the plan by stating, "To make the modern city livable is the task of our times."

so he lost his ability to influence the urban agenda—an agenda increasingly overrun by business interests that supported the Burnham/Wacker plan for Chicago,¹⁹ and beset by the heyday of Prohibition, bootleg booze, and gangsters. Jensen had helped shape Chicago but, like many other social reformers, he was becoming increasingly disillusioned with the city. As a result, he was now more inclined to denounce civilized society, proclaim the bankruptcy of mass-consumer capitalism, and look romantically toward the rural countryside for answers:

... to change the life of the pavement-minded is the most important problem before us today. With the growing of industry and commerce this problem is getting more and more acute. . . . Our cities of today have warped our minds to the extent that our musicians tell us a song without hope is harmony.

The city must look countryward for a new beginning or it is doomed. Never in the history of our cities have they sunk so low morally or spiritually. Never before have they reached as low a level of reasoning. To solve this mess in which we have sunk during these war years takes

deliberation and work with patience and sacrifice. . . . When the war hysteria has finally left us and we can again sit quietly and deliberate with great wisdom no living value will be sacrificed for profit. (Jensen, n.d.)

Thus, Jensen became increasingly concerned with the Babbitt-like conformity of modern America, the emphasis on mass marketing and consumerism.²⁰ This attempt to Americanize the populace through creating consumer needs appeared to him antithetical to his notion of a democratic, multi-cultural society.

Professionally, he found himself increasingly at odds with other landscape architects. He believed his colleagues' use of European-style garden designs was inappropriate for the United States, and he was not afraid to say so. As Leonard Eaton noted:

Jensen scorned the eastern landscape architects who designed formal Italianate gardens around New York, Philadelphia, and Boston. They were, he thought, simply repeating the outmoded forms of Europe. Even worse, they were bringing the artistic manifestation of political absolutism to a democratic republic where these forms had no place. For Jensen the *allée*, the *parterre*, and the grand boulevard were identified with autocratic government. (Eaton 1964, p. 16)

Jensen's scathing remarks about landscape design only exacerbated this philosophical rift between him and landscape architects from the eastern United States—a group he referred to as “the high priests.” His irritation with East Coast design ideas (ideas that Jensen saw as foreign—“Mediterranean nee Italianate,” “Oriental”) was heightened as the Prairie School style began to lose its influence in the Midwest, and as many of the artists Jensen had been associated with in Chicago moved to the East after the war (Brooks 1972, pp. 339–340).

Despite these tensions, Jensen continued working throughout the decade designing landscapes for residential estates, subdivisions, golf courses, schools, and hospitals. He remained committed to reform, but his focus was now on preserving areas of outstanding ecological significance and natural beauty. Ironically, he had placed himself in a position where he had to rely on wealthy clients to support his artistic expressions and land preservation ideals. In actuality, Jensen was part of the very economic system he railed against. Mertha Fulkerson, who began her career as Jensen's secretary during this period, recalled that “Jensen had become fashionable on the North Shore [of Chicago]—exactly what he himself hated, but he was blind to what was going on.” In addition, she pointed out that Jensen spent as much or more money than he earned, includ-

ing “heavy expenses for conservation propaganda” and full support of his office staff during good years and bad (Eaton 1960b).

Jensen was not alone in this turmoil over the withering Jeffersonian-Turnerian paradigm. The country, in general, was trying to find itself in the post-frontier, modern era. One group, which included the likes of Lewis Mumford, Vernon Paddington, Van Wyck Brooks, Benton MacKaye, Howard Odum, and Walter Prescott Webb, held sentiments similar to Jensen's. These regionalists, as they were known, spoke out for reform and against conformity, mass culture, and the demise of American folk culture. In his exposé of the regionalist movement, Robert L. Dorman portrays its proponents in this light:

Regionalists would, in sum, join this interwar modernist generation in the search for a new *integrated* culture and society. But if they were to share many modernist goals and assumptions, they often did so ambivalently, on their own terms and according to their own distinctive cultural and political agendas.

Closely associated with this preoccupation of the regionalist movement . . . would be regionalism's central emphasis on *place*, on the lived environment as a unique historical, cultural, and physical entity, and as a key to fully human life. . . . Their movement must be characterized as “nationalistic” (as it was), in perhaps the more positive connotation of the word: they believed that the materials for cultural reconstruction must be found at home, where time and nature had taught an appropriate wisdom. . . . Regionalists were to look to “native American” ideologies—such as republicanism, populism, or liberalism—rather than various “imported” creeds, to find their values and agendas, because, to their minds, such alien internationalist and industrialist doctrines ignored the saving, diversifying and decentralizing graces of place (a sentiment not without a “conservative” thread to be sure). (Dorman 1993, p. 23)

Like Jensen, these thinkers and writers were interested in capturing the essence of the American frontier and its agrarian spirit. They wanted to plot a new course for modern soci-

ety, one that celebrated “the folk” and embraced “living close to the land.” Jensen, having grown up with a healthy respect for folk traditions, emphasized “place-making” as part of his art. His work as part of the Prairie School made him a forerunner of the regionalists and their ideas and, unbeknownst to them, one of their contemporaries. Jensen revealed his feelings about retaining folk culture in a letter to a friend in Denmark:

Chicago . . . is swiftly ruining all that is left of American (colonial) culture in the surrounding country. To be yourself is the vital spark in all that is Danish and you must preserve it. Be proud of what you yourselves can produce besides admiring what other peoples can do—but do not copy them for then you will stand below them in cultural matters. Work that gives pleasure and spiritual satisfaction ennobles man—and it is just this that must be done—one's own people's cultural standing must be raised in peaceful competition in ennobling cultural work the world over. (Jensen 1934)

Jensen (and the regionalists) struggled with the tension between urban and rural society, modern and folk cultures throughout the latter part of the decade. But changes were ahead.

A series of events, beginning with the stock market crash in 1929 and ending with the death of his wife in 1934, transformed Jensen's life. The economic depression signaled the end of his estate work, while Ann Marie Jensen's death marked the loss of his life-long partner and confidante. Despite his misfortunes, the seventy-year-old Jensen emerged with a renewed sense of conviction. Capturing the spirit of the moment, he sensed the decay of capitalistic society and renewed his hope for a new order based on social democracy. Turning his business interests over to his son-in-law and business associate, Marshall Johnson, Jensen moved to the land he had purchased during the 1920s near Ellison Bay in Door County, Wisconsin.²¹ There he set about fulfilling several dreams, including establishing The Clearing (“A School of the Soil”) and writing *Siftings*. Reinvigorated in these primi-

tive surroundings—but often without the money or students to make his vision a reality—Jensen returned to his Danish roots. The cliffs overlooking Green Bay, the woodlands and farm fields of the surrounding countryside, and the months of quiet isolation brought him closer to his childhood in Schleswig and the rural life he now championed.

This last phase of Jensen's life is the time that Wolschke-Bulmahn found appropriate to quote from. It is a period when Jensen, who remained vigorous, outspoken, and flamboyant despite his advanced years, was without his wife or other peers to use as a sounding board for his ideas. In his move to Door County, he had completed an ideological journey (Rossi-Landi 1990) that began as part of an "idealist, reforming, but 'systematic' force" in Chicago, but now, at The Clearing, was more "utopian, subversive, and 'extra-systemic'." Thus, despite his optimism that the country had the opportunity to enter a more socially-responsible era, he held dark doubts about the future, was often more critical than ever, and less given to compromise than he was earlier in his career.²² The result is text with hyperbole and overstatements, but also containing poignant reflections and highly-perceptive insights regarding society and art.

This brief historical overview of Jensen's life and career is not intended to make excuses for him, an exercise that would be foolish and unnecessary. Always a man of deep conviction, he spoke his mind, reflecting his interpretation of ideas common to that historical era. Four key points can be made, however, regarding the recent controversy that connects Jensen, native plants, and the idea of Nordic superiority:

Point 1. There is no evidence to conclude that Jensen was a Nazi sympathizer. He remained true to his democratic and pacifist beliefs and saw Hitler's actions as another form of despicable human behavior. However, his dogmatic insistence about the effects of environment on art and national character—environmental determinism—remained.

Numerous writings by Jensen indicate his antipathy towards Hitler

and National Socialism. Early in Hitler's regime, he wrote in a letter to a Danish friend: "Things looks [sic] black in Germany—so black that it almost seems that they have gone mad. I am afraid they have entirely lost America's sympathy" (Jensen 1935). Following the outbreak of war, he wrote the following after describing a winter scene he observed from his kitchen door:

To see and sense the Master's brush in such living occurrences makes a lasting impression on one's consciousness. Many see it, but see it not. Therefore greed! Therefore jealousy! Therefore political racketeering! Therefore *Hitlerism!* (Jensen 1941a)

Jensen was disgusted by Hitler's totalitarianism and concerned by his military actions. He was further incensed by the European and American politicians who accepted his authoritarian regime. He believed too strongly in democracy and individual freedom to have followed any authoritarian figure, including Hitler. He said as much in a 1942 letter to his close friend Alfred Caldwell:

I still believe in the individual—not in mass production—not in Hitlerism. Only through the individual can we ever advance to greatness—not a one man's world—but many individual efforts, different like the crown on the tree. But as whole as a tree. That alone will give a rich life. (Jensen 1942a)

Furthermore, Jensen's belief in pacifism remained resolute throughout his life:

To fight with spiritual weapons is the way to eternal peace—the sword never wins—it destroys—there is no progress along that road—history proves it very clearly. (Jensen 1943a)

Finally, as Jensen explains in another letter to Alfred Caldwell, his idea of Germany was not Hitler's Germany and, as his reference to the Jewish poet, Heinrich Heine, indicates, its anti-Semitism:

Nietzsche—Superman—Hitler's forefather? I draw the line. My Germany is the Germany of Goethe, Beethoven, Schubert—even Heine. The Germany that was. (Jensen 1943b)

Jensen did, however, hold out hope for post-World War I Germany. He placed great value on that nation's cultural accomplishments and wanted to see the country recover from the aftermath of World War I. This desire to help Germany had its own Nordic roots since Jensen believed Scandinavian peoples to be the most peaceable in the world—a trait he hoped they might impress on the Germans:

I mentioned. . . that the youth of the Nordic countries sing "We want peace here at home" around the mid-summer eve bonfires. Those tones ring true and betoken a radiant morning for the Nordic peoples; indeed, for the entire Germanic race if it will join in. Let these tones ring out in the Schleswig schools—let Truth and the love of one's neighbour flourish there. Along that road we can advance—advance to a higher and better life on this earth—and that is all life has to offer us. (Jensen 1936a)

Like his fellow regionalists, Jensen may have been sympathetic to some of the anti-urban aspects of the *volk* rhetoric in Germany, and surely (if he knew of it) he must have welcomed legislation passed by the National Socialists in 1935 that protected animal and plant species, established nature preserves, and blocked industrialization in certain rural areas.²³ He indicates these sympathies in a letter to Alfred Caldwell, but also indicates his disdain for Hitler's tactics:

I am a little afraid of Hitler. Some of his ideas I like very much. But he is cruel. There is no need of that. It gets him nowhere. If England gets defeated shortly then there is no one for our help. We might just as well stay home and wait. The air is contaminated with nazism and communism, and whatever happens the world will not escape some of it. (Jensen 1941b)

This recognition of Hitler's cruelty was only too true as we now know. Jensen related this account of German cruelty to fellow Scandinavian William Evjue in 1944:

I have to tell you this terrible story I read last night in the Danish Press. . . . Paul Edion Kjer Sørensen was arrested on suspicion and put through 3rd degree by the German Gestapo.

After the Germans had killed Sörenson and buried him, Danish patriots dug up his grave and had his body examined by a qualified physician.

This is what the[y] found: His nails had been torn off [sic] his fingers and acid put in the wounds all the joints in his fingers except the little finger on his right hand had been broken. The left wrist was crushed and the right badly mangled. The right foot turned around so that it faced backward. He was shot through the mouth and in the chest.

How is that for odious—[can] even the Japs beat it?

I grieve for my people who have to suffer such cruelties—How far have we advanced in our much boasted civilization! (Jensen *circa* mid-1944)

In terms of garden design ideas in National Socialist Germany, Jensen certainly was aware of what was taking place, as can be noted in the following letter he received from Michael Meppes, editor of *Gartenkunst*:

I thank you very much for the newspaper clipping with the charming pictures of your purely personal garden and house design for the construction of your log cabin home in Ellison Bay, Wisconsin.

.... not only I, but rather a whole line of German garden designers strive for similar ideals. The intellectual turn of events since Adolf Hitler's taking office has brought that about. Even if we in Germany won't always reach this natural originality, such as you pursue in your gardens, since we lack the wide, untouched lands necessary; still we will indeed, through the newly awakened love of tradition of natural, untouched land come closer to your ideal. (Meppes 1936)

That same year Jensen wrote about Germany to his friend Frank Waugh:

They are really trying to do something over there. Whether they shall succeed or not I don't know, but there is a real urge. We seem to be dead. No creative thinking, no love for the work. We have grown lazy and indifferent. Our morale has sunk and our civilization is in a mess. We are selfish to the extreme all because we have made too much

money. We are now paying the penalty and we have not reached the bottom. (Jensen 1936b)

However, Jensen also criticized the National Socialist's use of baroque architecture as "too formal" and un-Germanic, expressing the same feelings he had about designs that were unsuited to a particular region or culture in the United States. An example of his thinking can be found in this excerpt from a letter to Michael Meppes:

Before me is *Gartenkunst*. I am searching for the new ideals of your Country and I fail to see much. It is all the restoration of old gardens. There are new things, but they smack of the Latin or the black man's intellect and not of yours—Mediterranean intellect is driving northward. It has penetrated into my Country and into the rest of my Scandinavian kin. Is this a spiritual weakness of the Germanic races—a weakness that is first shown in the arts—or is it intellectual laziness that often comes when the mind has been saturated with technical and material things in place of spiritual understanding? I am at a loss to know. (Jensen 1936c)

Regardless of his misgivings, Jensen did maintain ties to Germany during the period prior to World War II. As Wolschke-Bulmahn correctly points out, Jensen remained in contact with German landscape architects and landscape journal editors into the late 1930s. In fact, after encouragement from these German editors, Jensen submitted a paper on park and garden planning to the 1938 International Horticultural Congress that was held in Berlin (Jensen 1939a). However, this paper, which was read in Jensen's absence by his colleague, Franz Aust, and the other articles written during this decade contain only information about natural landscaping projects, and they certainly do not call for political action against any culture or religious group. It should also be noted that Jensen had published several articles in German landscape journals prior to the rise of the National Socialists in 1933, with some published as early as 1909 (Vernon 1995).

It is also important to clarify Wolschke-Bulmahn's assumption that

there was a collegial relationship between Jensen and Alwin Seifert. Jensen, in fact, never worked with, advised, or even corresponded with Seifert—hardly a collegial relationship. Furthermore, the claim that Jensen knew of Seifert's role in the National Socialist Party is pure conjecture. The letter from Camillo Schneider asking Jensen to comment on Seifert's work identifies Seifert as "Prof. Seifert" (Schneider 1938). Jensen's response to Schneider (not Seifert) indicates that he liked what he read in Seifert's articles in *Gartenschönheit*, but these were comments on Seifert's ideas for planting the Autobahn, and were not about racial or other aspects of National Socialist policy. Jensen had a long-standing interest in beautifying roadways through the use of native plantings. For example, he drew up and implemented plans for the "ideal section" of the Lincoln Highway in the early 1920s (his article about this was published in Germany in 1922, a decade before the National Socialists came to power; Jensen 1922). Moreover, Jensen's reply to Seifert's article, as cited by Wolschke-Bulmahn, was a response about the use of cultivars ("freaks" and "bastards").²⁴ It was a recommendation against a compromise in planting design, not a call to "militant" action against any group of people. Jensen's sharp language describes not human "freaks" of nature, but humanly-altered plants—plants that Jensen believed were manipulated unnecessarily and which showed a disrespect for "The Master's" (God's) creation. Jensen, reflecting on his own compromises, goes on to say in the same letter:

I will admit that I thought differently forty years ago when I pinched a border of our native aster (*Novae angliae*) to a height of about two feet. The effect was marvelous and no one recognized the common prairie aster in this showy border. But that was some time ago! Why dwarf and distort the natural beauty of our friends? Would you like to have your fingers clipped off? (Jensen April 15, 1939, p.3)

Point 2. Jens Jensen lived in an era when race and ethnicity were very real dividing lines in American society—lines that even today are only

beginning to blur. He did, as did most people of his generation, categorize different groups of people by a racial or ethnic identity: "Mediterraneans," "Chinamen," "Japs," "Blacks," "Hindus," and "Latins." He recognized himself as "Nordic" and felt a strong attachment to that culture.

We must ask ourselves: does Jensen's mention of race, or his making distinctions between races or ethnic groups make him a racist? Does it mean that he did accept, or would have accepted, the National Socialist "blood-and-soil" ideology, as charged (Wolschke-Bulmahn 1996, p. 9)? Or that his garden designs supported fascism?

Webster's Unabridged Dictionary defines "racism" as:

A program or practice of racial discrimination, segregation, persecution, and domination based on a doctrine or feeling of racial differences or antagonisms, especially with reference to supposed racial superiority, inferiority, or purity; racial prejudice. (p. 1485)

Reflecting on this definition, Jensen deserves the label of "racist" only in the sense that he believed that there were different races. There are no indications that Jensen thought the Nordic race was superior, or that it should rule any other race. Unlike the National Socialists, he did not believe that war or genocide was the answer to racial problems. Instead, Jensen championed the notion of separate but equal cultures—a country of strength through cultural diversity. On the issue of purity, he firmly believed in remaining "true" or authentic to one's "race" or culture—a position he learned as a child in Denmark. His views on art and society reflected this position, especially later in his life. For example, in this excerpt from a letter to Franz Aust he notes:

Marvelous isn't it—the introduction of Oriental art into our Western civilization? But only a people in decay will accept it. It matters little whether they are Danes in Denmark or Americans in America. The home is the first thing a man builds—it must be true to him—a part of him—not a plaything—a novelty. You cannot accept your house from foreign lands without

being subservient to that land. It is the Englishman under the thatched roof of England that fights for his freedom; the descendent of the Saxon and the Dane, not the lord in the castle with foreign architecture in foreign gardens! He is doomed—he will go—but the thatched roof will stay! England harbors a composite people, so does America. There will be changes ever to climatic and environmental conditions but not in the general structural plan. The thatched house will still be the thatched house, it will survive—or the decay of a people will destroy it and another people take their place. It is so written in the stars—art is a growth like a tree—not the whim and notion of those that prefer to be what they are not. Art cannot be forced, neither learned; it is a God-given gift.—Only the truth will prevail—words are just words. What we need is more sincerity, more honesty in our daily life. We are rootless—we have drifted on roller-skates away from the honesty of the soil into a life of charlatans and stooges and would-bes and lazy louts. . . . Let us get down to the fundamentals of a simple living, a simple life-struggle for what we get. Nothing is worth having that does not take an effort to get. Life is serious. As a people we have forgotten this—forgotten our struggling pioneer forefathers. We will learn it—a most bitter lesson—or lose our freedom. (Jensen 1942b)

Wolschke-Bulmahn states that Jensen was strongly influenced by the National Socialist ideology of "blood-and-soil." However, Jensen's so-called "racial motives" reflect a belief in environmental determinism, not necessarily racial superiority. In his mind everyone fit within a world of diverse cultures—cultures with traits that should be maintained, especially in an increasingly acultural world.

In addition, Jensen's efforts to get back in touch with the simple life of "the soil" (a move made by others in the United States during the 1930s and again in the 1970s) does not indicate that he was a racist. Those actions suggest more strongly his fears (and the fears of others) that modern, consumer society was destroying, rather than enhancing, the lives of Americans. Jensen was a man who grew up without automobiles, radios, phonograph records, and

the trappings of modernity, and while he couldn't escape them entirely (he loved to drive automobiles, for instance), he built his homes and landscaped his yards specifically to help him maintain his sense of personal integrity and heritage.

Did Jensen use the emergence of "Latin" and "Oriental" art as a scapegoat for this decline of culture and advance of "civilization"? We believe that he did. However, we also feel that he struggled with this issue (note the sentence from *Die Lichtung/The Clearing* [1937 *Gartenkunst*]): "Latin spirit has spoiled a lot and still spoils things every day; and only sometimes might it be good and enrich our world of forms." Jensen wanted desperately for each culture to maintain its artistic identity, and to do so within a regional context. Yet the phrase, "and only sometimes might it be good and enrich our world of forms" suggests that he felt there was some room for positive cross-cultural influences and compromise.

Finally, for Wolschke-Bulmahn to suggest that landscape architects such as Jensen or Willy Lange had any influence on the racial policies of National Socialism in Germany is an exaggeration at best. Should Jensen have realized that he was an instrument of a racist regime? Perhaps, but then how many of today's landscape architects stop to consider their roles within the corporate, global economy with all its injustices (Greider 1997)?

Point 3. Unlike Wolschke-Bulmahn and Gröening, we do not believe that the exclusive use of "pure strains" of plants is morally wrong or an indicator of a repressive social structure. Gardening of any sort—vegetable gardening, landscape design, ecological restoration—depends to some extent on human preference. To garden or design landscapes is to cultivate, an activity that requires human action and choice, and is essentially and linguistically tied to the word culture. No matter how well we are able to disguise the human "hand" in our landscaping efforts (and Jensen could do it better than most), our preferences for one plant over another will not disappear. No matter which style we use—formal or informal, eclectic or native—there are choices to be

made. There is no moral high ground here for natural landscape advocates, Wolschke-Bulmahn, Michael Pollan, or anyone else.

If the real problem is, as Wolschke-Bulmahn suggests (1997, p. 6), that "nature is ideology," then we might ask: What part of this ideology includes the choice of planting a natural landscape based on an ecological model of a plant community? And what part includes the choice of planting a cosmopolitan garden using plants from all over the world? And what part includes the choice of planting a garden based on a formal French design? Maybe there are no problems with these three visions of nature and gardening—garden as natural history, garden as natural cornucopia, garden as natural geometry—until these ideas about nature become part of a political regime. But does that regime have to be the Nationalist Socialists of Germany? Are there others? We believe that every nation involved in colonization has tried to impose their view of nature on the places and people they colonized. Take, for example, the American government's policy of removal and war against the native peoples of this country, and its subsequent policies for populating the land with immigrants. These policies of an ideology known as "Manifest Destiny" completely transformed the prairies, savannas, wetlands, and woodlands into commodities, enabling the immigrant population to prosper at the expense of these natural features and the Native American population. Moreover, the United States government has been making specific decisions about which plants to promote and which to ban for decades through plant quarantines, the passage of the plant patent law, and through the propagation and promotion of "superior" cultivars and exotic plants by agencies such as the Soil Conservation Service (now the National Resources Conservation Service). In many cases, such as the importation of kudzu and reed canary grass, and the propagation and distribution of the multiflora rose, the results have been disastrous to the present environment. Thus, we don't need to look to the National Socialist experiment with the "Germanization" of occupied

Poland (Gröening and Wolschke-Bulmahn 1987) to understand how a political regime can transform an ideology into a human and natural tragedy. Having said that, we should also be mindful that while gardens have supported existing power structures at Versailles, the Kyoto Imperial Palace, and the White House through times of war and peace, cases of genocide and human tragedy have taken place where formal ideas about garden designs and environmental matters were not even part of the culture.

Unfortunately, most landscape architects are not schooled in politics, and have little appreciation for the dynamics of a political system. Jensen, despite his idealization of democracy, was no different. Furthermore, his unyielding integrity made it difficult for him to work in situations that required a compromise of his ideals. In his heart, Jensen recognized that his public projects brought him the greatest satisfaction and, perhaps, his greatest influence.²⁵ Who would deny the role of Jensen's many park projects in creating healthy, stimulating environments for people? The same could be said for Jensen's conservation work: the Forest Preserve Districts of metropolitan Chicago, the Indiana Dunes, the Ridges Sanctuary in Door County, and other significant natural areas. When you can influence your fellow citizens, you have power in a democracy. However, such power is ephemeral and fleeting if it is not maintained and adapted to the changes within the culture, something Jensen failed, at least in part, to understand and accomplish.

Point 4. As environmental designers, landscape architects must come to terms with the questions of "if" and "how" both natural and human-shaped environments influence culture and behavior. We should not take these questions lightly and certainly should not view them in the manner Jensen did when he stereotyped nationalities according to various climatic and topographic features.²⁶ As a paradigm for geography, environmental determinism has long since been recognized as outmoded and dangerous (Sauer 1967, p. 315; Wirth 1965, p. 382).

Does this mean that landscape

architects must give up the idea of "sense of place" or that regionally-appropriate landscape plans must give way to a cosmopolitan style? We don't think so. Place is still an important force in human life. But it is not a single-factor, mechanistic construct like environmental determinism. Place is multi-faceted, dynamic, and it changes with time. For example, geographer Robert Sack holds that place is important because it represents the interaction between human meaning, social relations, and nature (Sack 1998). Because we live in a world that continues to be increasingly interconnected and homogeneous, the social relations and meaning people bring to nature will reflect that widely-traveled, cosmopolitan world. However, there are others who remember an earlier time when meanings were more localized, and still others who know nothing of those times yet seek a similar connection to the natural world that provides a place for their home. This suggests that as landscape architects concerned with placemaking we must recognize the dynamics of both the natural and cultural systems of our clients and find ways to bring them into our designs (Figure 6). Our planning and design efforts should emphasize the "bottom-up" principles of community involvement that Jensen advocated, and which are being implemented by contemporary landscape architectural firms such as Andropogon Associates (Sauer 1998). Advances in user-survey techniques and other methods of obtaining demographic and behavioral information, along with the usual array of natural resource studies, should also become part of every site analysis and land planning endeavor (Casagrande 1997).

The day when Jensen could write:

To be inspired by and to create parks and gardens out of the beauty and composition of our native landscape is a much higher accomplishment than to form a garden with varieties of plants that have no intimate association with each other or with us and which at best become mere patch work influenced by the curious and scientific mind. (Jensen 1990, p. 5)



Figure 6. A rock garden at the Kenneth D. Alexander estate in Spring Station, Kentucky. Completed in 1917, it exemplified the naturalistic style Jensen preferred and used almost exclusively throughout his career. Photograph courtesy of Robert E. Grese.

may never return, but it does not mean that today's natural gardens do not have a legitimate place in our present social system—a place that deserves respect for its accomplishments, and understanding for its position as a mnemonic vehicle that can help us reconnect with the ecological and cultural history of the region we call home. Placemaking of this kind is not about ethnic identity, but it remains focused on relating to our individual and group identity, whatever that may be. It is one method and, like all our attempts to re-connect to the natural world, it has its imperfections. It is a subtle pathway to help stem the rising tide of place-deprivation. Acts of designing, cultivating, and caring for natural gardens or restorations provide both meaning and memory for those who need to feel connected to, and empowered by, their dwelling places. These efforts serve to remind us that the world—both natural and cultural—needs biodiversity, rather than homogeneity, to survive and flourish.

Conclusion

If we accept the idea of engaging the memory of their clients and

the region they inhabit, then landscape architects, restorationists, and environmentalists must also recognize that the core ideas which underlie their disciplines were formed as an antidote to the emergence of modern America. As such we need to acknowledge that a strong, persistent theme of impending social and natural decline pervades these practices and, in fact, gives them their charge: to beautify, restore, and preserve. Because this places us in a position where we often see the dark side of modernity (as Jensen surely did), we must admit our fears that all will be lost while maintaining our belief in our democratic institutions and our own abilities to affect responsible social change. We must use our authority as experts wisely.

Will “a new social structure founded on the soil” emerge from the act of planting and maintaining a natural garden or a prairie restoration? Perhaps. And, keeping the memory of our native landscape alive and respecting Jensen for his contributions—mistakes and all—demands that we keep trying.

Notes

1. Papers of Franz Aust. Wisconsin State Historical Archives: Madison. Franz Aust was a colleague of Jensen's. Aust met Jensen while working for the Illinois Agricultural Extension Program. Later, as a professor of Horticulture at the University of Wisconsin-Madison, Aust continued as one of Jensen's confidants and supporters. He headed the Wisconsin chapter of the Friends of Our Native Landscape, helped Jensen obtain students for *The Clearing*, and persuaded the University to give Jensen an honorary degree in 1937. In August 1938, Aust went to Berlin to deliver an address for Jensen, in his absence, to the International Horticultural Congress (Internationaler Gartenbau Kongress).

2. Although the Green Party in Germany has a decidedly socialist image, it has, on occasion, been infiltrated by right-wing extremists. For example, in 1984 the entire Green Party in Berlin was expelled from the country-wide Green Party because it had been taken over by neo-Nazis. See Horst Mewes (1985), “The Green Party Comes of Age,” *Environment* 27(5):13–17, 33–39.

3. On 26 April 1994, U.S. President William J. Clinton sent a memo to the heads of executive departments and agencies that states:

“Because the Federal Government owns and landscapes large areas of land, our stewardship presents a unique opportunity to provide leadership in this area and to develop practical and cost-effective methods to preserve and protect that which has been entrusted to us. Therefore, for Federal grounds, Federal projects, and Federally-funded projects, I direct that agencies shall, where cost-effective and to the extent practicable: (a) use regionally native plants for landscaping; (b) design, use, or promote construction practices that minimize adverse effects on the natural habitat; . . . (c) create outdoor demonstrations incorporating native plants. . . . To enhance landscaping options and awareness, the Department of Agriculture shall conduct research on the suitability, propagation, and use of native plants for landscaping. The Department shall make available to agencies and the public the results of this research.” (The White House, Office of the Press Secretary). Also see *The Washington Post* article, “Commander in Leaf.” (April 29, 1994, p. A2)

4. At roughly the same time Pollan was making these statements about natural gardening, he wrote the following as part of his Introduction to *Natural Gardening* (1995, John Kadel Boring et. al., Berkeley, California: The Nature Company): “As the natural gardener soon appreciates, one needn't travel to the wilderness in order to observe the workings of a rich and vital ecosystem. In fact, you hold in your hands a tool with which to establish such an ecosystem in your own backyard. Part instruction manual and part field guide, *Natural Gardening* will show you, step by step, how to improve the ecology of your particular corner of the Earth—to make it more alive. What could be more worthwhile than that?”

5. Chamberlain (1855–1927), was an English-born Germanophile who loved Richard Wagner's work, especially its heroic, Teutonic aspects.

6. Adolf Hitler liked Chamberlain's ideas and, from reading Chamberlain's work, developed an appreciation of Gobineau. Alfred Rosenberg (1893–1946), the editor of the National Socialist Party newspaper, *Völkischer Beobachter* (*Nationalist Observer*), also drew upon the ideas of Chamberlain and on the *Protocols of the Learned Elders of Zion*, a nineteenth-century fabrication that warned of a Jewish plot for world domination. In 1934, Rosenberg wrote *Der Mythos des 20. Jahrhunderts* (*The Myth of the 20th Century*). In this work, he maintained that the Germans were descendants from a Nordic race that derived its character from its environment: a pure, cold, semi-Arctic continent, now disappeared. As representatives of this Nordic race, Germans had a right to dominate Europe and their enemies—the “Russian Tartars” and the “Semites,” which included Jews, Latin peoples, and Catholics.

7. While nativist thought in the United States was influenced very little by Europeans, both sides of the Atlantic reached the same conclusion—racial hatred grounded in fear and based on scientific “knowledge.” American nativist theoreticians such as William Z. Ripley (*The Races of Europe*, 1899) and Madison Grant (*The Passing of the Great Race*, 1916) drew their ideas from the new findings in anthropology and Mendelian genetics. Ripley argued that human physiological traits were a reflection of geographical and social conditions in Europe—thus there existed the Teutonic, Alpine, and Mediterranean races. Grant carried this idea further and, in doing so, downplayed the ideas of democracy and humanism in favor of race and the status quo. See John Higham, *Strangers in the Land*. 1955, pp. 153–157.

8. The German-American Bund was a fascist, quasi-Nazi organization that emerged in the United States during the 1930s. While vocal and pesky at local levels, it never succeeded in widely establishing itself and disbanded when the United States entered World War II. See Morris Schonbach, *Native American Fascism during the 1930s and 1940s* (1987), L. V. Bell, *In Hitler's Shadow: The Anatomy of American Nazism* (1973), and S.A. Diamond, *The Nazi Movement in the United States, 1924–1941* (1974). For a Wisconsin perspective, see Dieter Berninger 1988, “Milwaukee's German-American community and the Nazi challenge of the 1930s,” *Wisconsin Magazine of History* 71(2):118–142.

9. Here we acknowledge our debt to the ideas of the British historian, R. G. Collingwood who advocated that historians attempt to “take the historical actor's place” and thereby learn the rationale beyond the actions of a historical figure. See R.G. Collingwood, *The Idea of History* (1946).

10. Turner saw the process as an evolutionary sequence: “The frontier begins with the Indian and the hunter; it goes on to tell of the disintegration of savagery by the entrance of the trader, the pathfinder of civilization; we read the annals of the pastoral stage in ranch life; the exploitation of the soil by raising of unrotated crops of corn and wheat in sparsely settled farming communities; the intensive culture of the denser farm settlement; and finally the manufacturing organization with city and factory system.” From *The Frontier in American History* (1920).

11. The Progressives—an upper-middle class, reform-minded, political and social movement—generally disliked or mistrusted the unbridled capitalism of their day, sought to check political “machines” and graft, had a high sense of morality and altruism, embraced the idea of conserving natural resources and, generally sought solutions for a “better life” for all citizens (although they neglected Native Americans and African-Americans). They believed in the power of science (often as found in university settings) coupled with a democratic, but paternal, government as the primary agent of change. Politically, they were a mid-western phenomenon that spread to other parts of the country. The political party made two runs for the Presidency of the United States. One in 1912 with Theodore Roosevelt as their candidate, and, in 1924, with Robert LaFollette. (See *History of the Progressive Party 1912–1916*, Amos R. E. Pinchot [1958] New York: New York University Press; and *The Progressive Movement of 1924 and the Development of Interest Group Liberalism*, David L. Waterhouse [1991] New York: Garland Publishing).

12. See Jensen, “Landscape Appreciation,” *Wisconsin Horticulture* 1927 (May), p. 130. “Masters like Louis Sullivan, Frank L. Wright, Walter Griffin, Vachel Lindsay and Carl Sandburg are all of mid-America growth. It [the prairie] has inspired a distinct type of architecture, decorative design, and a new form of poetry . . . In politics and the industries we have such men as Lincoln and Henry Ford.”

13. For insights into this aspect of Chicago and Jensen's career there see *Prairie in the City: Naturalism in Chicago's Parks, 1870–1940 or A Breath of Fresh Air: Chicago's Neighborhood Parks of the Progressive Era, 1900–1925*. The Special Park Commission's 1905 report details some of the conditions residents of the city were facing: “The residents of the 11th ward, more than 60,500 in number, according to a recent estimate, are largely foreign, of various races, from Germany, Austria and Russia. There is no park in this ward and for the little ones only a small playground in the southwest end conducted by Gad's Hill Center. Long, dreary brown stretches of lumber yards, mills, railroad tracks and factories radiate heat day and night” (p. 11).

14. Louis Sullivan in *Kindergarten Chats* (1918) wrote, “Democracy is primarily of the individual! It is not a mere political fabric, a form of government: that is but one phase of it—an incidental phase. Democracy is a moral principle, a spiritual law, a perennial subjective reality in the realm of man's spirit. It is an aspiring power whose roots run deep in those primal forces that have caused man to rise from the elements of the earth. . . . Democracy is a vast, slowly-urging impulse which little by little and more and more broadly is ever exalting man in spirit and imparting to him a definition of his true image—his true powers (p. 97). Later in the book, he writes, “It is the essence of Democracy that the individual man is free in his body and free in his soul. It is a corollary therefrom, that he must govern or restrain himself, both as to bodily acts and mental acts—that, in short, he must set up a responsible government within his own individual person. It implies that highest form of emancipation—of liberty, physical, mental and spiritual, by virtue whereof man calls the gods to judge-

ment, while he heeds the divinity of his own soul” (p. 221). As Chris Vernon (1995, p. 236) suggests, and is abundantly evident from Jensen's writings and letters, democracy and individual responsibility were at the forefront of Jensen's political and moral ideology.

15. Chicago was the scene of race riots in the summer of 1919. The following year, U.S. Attorney General, A. Mitchell Palmer conducted what became known as the “Palmer raids,” in which federal and state agents arrested “foreign radicals.” Even well-known pacifists such as Jane Addams came under the scrutiny of the federal government. See Robert K. Murray, 1955, *Red Scare, a Study in National Hysteria, 1919–1920*.

16. See Stephen Jay Gould, *The Mismeasure of Man*, (1981, New York: Norton), for a penetrating discussion and debunking of the Army Mental Tests. The results of these biased tests, which claimed that intelligence levels in the United States were falling because of immigration by southern and eastern Europeans, provided the “scientific” basis for the passage of the Immigration Restriction Act of 1924. As Gould points out these restrictions lasted well into the 1930s and kept millions of European Jews from entering the United States, where they would have avoided the Holocaust (p. 233). Also see Kelves, *In the Name of Eugenics: Genetics and the Uses of Human Heredity* (1985, New York: Knopf), for information about these tests (pp. 80–82, 129–130).

17. Sixteen states in the United States, representing every region in the country except the South, passed compulsory sterilization laws between 1907 and 1917. Persons who were seen as being habitual criminals, rapists, insane, sexually promiscuous, or epileptics were candidates for the procedure. Sociologists and biologists, acting as experts within the Progressive method of policy making, provided “scientific” support for these undertakings. There was vigorous opposition to this practice, however, and by 1917 sterilization laws were in such dispute that several courts had declared them unconstitutional. In 1927, the issue of constitutionality was settled in a landmark Supreme Court case—*Buck v. Bell*. Justice Oliver Wendell Holmes wrote the decision that upheld the sterilization laws and by the end of the decade twenty-four states had such laws on their books. (Twenty-two states still have these laws in place, although they are severely limited by federal regulation.) Kelves writes, “German eugenicists . . . said they owed a great debt to American precedent, including the report of Gosney and Popenoe [*Sterilization for Human Betterment*] on the California program” (Kelves, pp. 114–118).

18. Calvin Coolidge, “Whose Country is This?” *Good Housekeeping* (February 1921), p. 14.

19. Daniel Burnham published his plan for Chicago in 1909. It included a formal arrangement of streets much like those used in Washington, D.C. and many European cities. Jensen, as chairman of the City Club's committee on city planning, fought this plan as being too formal and lacking in direction on issues such as housing. The debate over the Burnham plan went on for years before a version of it was finally accepted. Jensen devised his own plan, *A Greater West Park System*, which treated some of the same areas as the Burnham plan but added

elements of the English garden city movement such as neighborhood centers, clustered housing surrounded by open space, and neighborhood gardens. It was never adopted. See Carol Doty, "Ecology, Community, and Prairie Spirit" in *Prairie in the City: Naturalism in Chicago's Parks, 1870–1940*.

20. George Babbitt is the protagonist in Sinclair Lewis's novel, *Babbitt*. Babbitt is confronted with the conformity required of the efficient modern. He tries to escape but cannot, due to his own shallowness and lack of spiritual depth. Lewis intimates that technology is a barrier to intimacy with ourselves, others, and nature.

21. According to Mertha Fulkerson, Jensen was "marking time" for the last two or three years he lived in Chicago, but he "would not have left while Mrs. Jensen was alive." (Jensen Papers, Eaton File, Eaton interview with Mertha Fulkerson, August, 1960). Bob Grese writes, "Mrs. Jensen always enjoyed these visits [to the land at Ellison Bay], but she was not anxious to live there on a year-round basis. She had no desire to trade her Danish friends in Chicago for the isolation of Ellison Bay." (Grese 1992, p. 140).

22. Regarding the use of non-American plants by Jensen, Grese writes "Jensen never entirely stopped using horticultural varieties, even in his later work. As Alfred Caldwell, [Jensen's most trusted foreman] pointed out, Jensen tried to provide what the client wanted as part of an overall composition. If this included exotic plants, Jensen would group them in a special garden or in an area near the house." (Grese 1992, p. 152).

23. Gröening and Wolschke-Bulmahn indicate that this legislation, known as the Nature Protection Law, "was not actually intended to implement any nature protection measures, but was, rather, a propaganda tool of the National Socialists, and especially Reich Forest Master Göring." (Gröening and Wolschke-Bulmahn 1987, p. 131). If Jensen was aware of this legislation, he, too, could have been fooled into believing that it was an honest effort. Moreover, if it was propaganda, it brings into question the true relationship between ecology, war-making, and racial genocide within the policymaking levels of the National Socialist Party.

24. The full quote is as follows: "Seifert seems to distinguish between the garden inside and enclosure and the landscape—here he submits to compromise. He speaks about *Acer Wieriei Lancinatum*. I do not know it, but the long name attracted my attention. To me it remains a stranger weakened by the fact that its foliage is cut [a reference to "*Lancinatum*"]. There may be natural causes that makes for differences in plant characteristics, and I can accept them if the plant has not been weakened by this procedure. I cannot see how you can compromise. . . ." (Jensen to Camillo Schneider, April 15, 1939).

25. In an interview with Malcolm Collier, Alfred Caldwell relates that Jensen felt it was "a great tragedy that I am always doing these estates for these rich. . . . I shouldn't be doing these places. I should be doing great regional parks. That is what I love. That is what I wanted to do. That is the meaning of my life." (Alfred Caldwell, interview by Malcolm Collier, January 1981, tape no. 8:19. Morton Arboretum).

26. The Smithsonian Institute, working with Harvard University's Frederick Putnam and Franz Boas, developed ethnological displays for the 1893 Columbian Exposition in Chicago. Recently, the Secretary of the Smithsonian Institute, Michael Heyman wrote regarding these displays: "Less inspiring were the ways in which people and their cultures were depicted at the Exposition. In retrospect, the framework for the living exhibitions was an oversimplified evolutionary one. It categorized cultures in racial terms, separating the so-called primitive from the civilized, and drew unwarranted conclusions about moral and material progress and superiority. People were spoken about and displayed as if they were specimens of a type without a voice of their own." See *Smithsonian* 1996. *Smithsonian Perspectives*. 27(4):14. Jensen maintained this Eurocentric perspective, see *Siftings*, Chapter 3, Environmental Determinants.

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